

Serviceberry

Amelanchier laevis

Allegheny Shadbush · Juneberry



QUALITIES

A small multi-stem tree or large shrub of the rose family, growing 15 to 25 feet at maturity with a graceful rounded crown. Smooth pale-gray bark, and oval finely-toothed leaves that emerge bronze-purple, mature to soft green, and turn brilliant orange-red in fall. White five-petaled flowers appear in drooping clusters before the leaves in mid-April — one of the earliest woody bloomers in the Minnesota landscape — followed in June by dark purple edible berries that birds strip in a few days.

CARE

Plant in fall or early spring as a 6 to 8 ft balled-and-burlapped specimen, not bare-root. Full sun to part shade; tolerates loam, clay, or sandy soils so long as drainage is reasonable. Drought-tolerant once established. No regular pruning required; remove the occasional sucker to maintain a single-trunk or open multi-stem form. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Avoid waterlogged sites and overly rich soils — they encourage soft growth that's prone to fire blight.

HISTORY

The name "serviceberry" descends from "sorbus," the Latin name for a related fruit. To the Anishinaabe and Dakota of Minnesota this tree is "Juneberry" — its fruits, eaten raw or pounded with meat and fat into pemmican, were among the first fresh foods of the year. Lewis & Clark recorded the species as a key wild food of the Great Plains, and it has been in continuous cultivation since.

REASON TO BE

A serviceberry is a small ecological universe. April flowers feed early-emerging native bees when almost nothing else is open. June berries feed Cedar Waxwings, Robins, Catbirds, and dozens of other songbirds. Its leaves host the larvae of more than a hundred native moth and butterfly species. In a designed garden it offers four seasons of structure — spring bloom, summer fruit, fiery fall color, winter silhouette. Plant it as the anchor and the rest of the garden gathers around it.